

those that would give me the widest geographical distribution. I next concentrated on MSS with a ‘perfect’ profile. Of course, I was limited by the availability of MSS in PDF. With my family profile for the whole NT, I can quickly identify any f^{35} MS that has yet to be studied. That is how Iviron 2110 and Leukosia 65 got in (they have not yet been assigned a number by INTF, as of this writing).

Looking at the chart, eleven MSS have an average of only one variant per three chapters or more—exceptional! (MS 586 is all but perfect as it stands.) Another nine MSS have only one variant per two chapters—excellent. Virtually 40% are excellent or better. Another seventeen have only one variant per chapter—good. Another twelve have two variants per chapter—fair. Another three have three variants per chapter—poor. One MS has five variants per chapter—marginal. Note that the very worst of the fifty-three f^{35} representatives (1199, e, XII, Sinai) is four times ‘better’ than Colwell’s very best Alexandrian representative, Codex L. Stop for a moment and think about the implications. How can any sane person defend the proposition that the Alexandrian text-type represents the best line of transmission?¹

A representative case

In the opening paragraph I stated that variants can be evaluated. I will now take one of the merely ‘fair’ f^{35} representatives—MS 1384, eapr, XI, Andros—list its variants and evaluate them.

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| 1:17 | γενεσθαι --- 1384 [the verb must be understood in any case; the meaning is not altered] |
| 1:44 | προσενεγκαι προσενεγκε [75%] 1384 + five [these forms were used interchangeably, so they are virtually alternate spellings of the same word] |
| 2:17 | εχοντες 1 και 1384 [he merely supplied an implied conjunction; there is no change in the basic meaning] |
| 3:12 | πολλα --- 1384 [this does not change the basic meaning] |

¹ I here repeat a sentence from Colwell’s paragraph: “These results show convincingly that any attempt to reconstruct an archetype of the Beta Text-type on a quantitative basis is doomed to failure.” “These results show convincingly” something else: those copyists were not encumbered with any special respect or consideration for what they were copying. Obviously, they did not believe that they were copying a sacred text, which makes one wonder why they would expend time and material in so doing. I see one explanation that makes sense: they were deliberately perverting the text, presumably under Satanic or demonic influence. By way of contrast, the care with which most f^{35} copyists did their work implies a high degree of respect for the text being copied. If God were concerned to preserve His Text, what sort of copyist would He use? What sort of copyist would the Holy Spirit protect and bless? [Since both God and Satan exist, someone who excludes the supernatural from his model is being naïve in the extreme.]